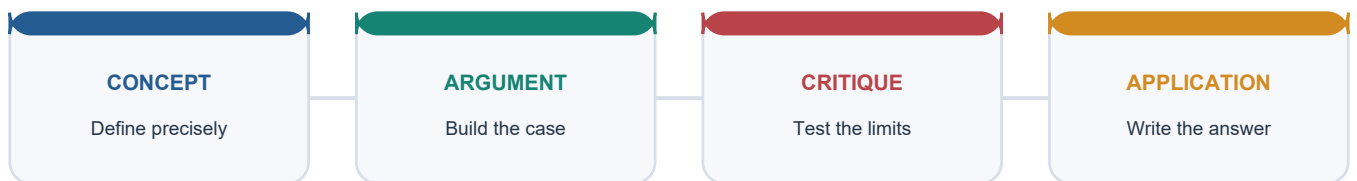


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Iranian and Macedonian Invasions: Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Iranian and Macedonian Invasions: Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: exactly 32 original hard/remedial MCQs precede the PYQ audit; strict ABCD rotation repeats eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 traps are unique.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

These are original questions, not UPSC PYQs. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times.

Q1

Which statement best uses Darius I's DNA inscription?

- A. It names Gandara and Hindush among subject countries without surveying their borders.
- B. It proves every Punjab locality paid the same assessed tax directly to Susa and supplies one uniform fiscal code for every eastern district.
- C. It records Alexander's appointment of Porus after Hydaspes.
- D. It dates the invention of Kharoshthi to one named royal scribe.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: DNA securely attests both eastern names inside Darius's claimed imperial geography. [Q1-A]
- **B:** A royal list gives no uniform assessment schedule or locality-by-locality administrative map. [Q1-B]
- **C:** Alexander's campaign belongs to the fourth century BCE and later classical narratives. [Q1-C]
- **D:** No Achaemenid inscription identifies a single inventor or foundation date for Kharoshthi. [Q1-D]

Examiner trap 1: Country-list inclusion is stronger than border or bureaucracy reconstruction.

Q2

Why is c. 518/516 BCE written with caution?

- A. It is the exact day stated in the Behistun inscription for Punjab's annexation and fixes the same direct-rule boundary for every locality in the Punjab.
- B. It is a textbook reconstruction of Darius's eastward extension, not a self-dated conquest charter.
- C. It dates Xerxes's invasion of Greece and therefore cannot concern India.
- D. It is the year Cyrus certainly conquered the whole Indus and Ganga basins.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Behistun names Gandara but does not supply this exact annexation date or a Punjab charter. [Q2-A]
- **B:** Correct: The date is useful chronology, while process, border and administrative depth remain reconstructed. [Q2-B]
- **C:** Xerxes invaded Greece in 480 BCE; the Darius convention concerns an earlier eastern extension. [Q2-C]
- **D:** Cyrus's exact Indian conquests are uncertain and no Ganga-wide claim is defensible. [Q2-D]

Examiner trap 2: A conventional date organises chronology; it must not manufacture precision.

Q3

Which pairing is correct?

- A. Hydaspes-Beas and Hyphasis-Jhelum while treating both names as exact synonyms in every classical itinerary.
- B. Hydaspes-Ravi and Hyphasis-Chenab
- C. Hydaspes-Jhelum and Hyphasis-Beas
- D. Hydaspes-Indus delta and Hyphasis-Makran

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This reverses the battle river and the limit-of-advance river. [Q3-A]
- **B:** Ravi is Hydraotes and Chenab is Acesines in the standard nomenclature. [Q3-B]
- **C:** Correct: Porus fought at Hydaspes/Jhelum; the army stopped at Hyphasis/Beas. [Q3-C]
- **D:** Patala and Makran belong to the return route, not these Punjab river names. [Q3-D]

Examiner trap 3: Similar Greek H-names are a deliberate map trap.

Q4

What is the safest claim about Cyrus II?

- A. He created a uniform Indian satrapy from Kabul to Pataliputra under a centrally surveyed frontier that continued unchanged to the Ganga.
- B. He introduced Ashokan edicts in Kharoshthi.
- C. His conquest date is fixed by a surviving Indus expedition diary.
- D. He may have approached the eastern frontier, but firm Indian incorporation is first defensible under Darius.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** No evidence supports a Ganga-wide Cyrus province or a uniform frontier grid. [Q4-A]
- **B:** Ashokan inscriptions are third-century BCE Mauryan documents, long after Cyrus. [Q4-B]
- **C:** No Cyrus-era Indus expedition diary survives to provide such precision. [Q4-C]
- **D:** Correct: Later eastern traditions are possible antecedents, while Darius supplies firmer inscriptions. [Q4-D]

Examiner trap 4: Do not upgrade an antecedent tradition into a securely mapped conquest.

Q5

Behistun is most useful here because it:

- A. Names Gandara within Darius's imperial geography while serving an accession-legitimacy program.
- B. Lists Hindush alone and omits every other eastern land and identifies each listed eastern people as one identical fiscal province.
- C. Provides audited tribute receipts from the twentieth district.
- D. Narrates the Battle of Hydaspes from Porus's perspective.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Gandara is attested, but the inscription's political-rhetorical purpose still matters. [Q5-A]
- **B:** Behistun lists many lands; Hindush is clearer in later Darius lists such as DNa. [Q5-B]
- **C:** The tribute-district report is Herodotus, not a Behistun account ledger. [Q5-C]
- **D:** Hydaspes occurred much later and survives mainly through Greek and Roman authors. [Q5-D]

Examiner trap 5: Contemporaneity increases value but does not cancel royal ideology.

Q6

How should Herodotus's 360 talents of gold dust be treated?

- A. As an exact rupee-equivalent tax audited by modern accounting rules including a fixed silver conversion and an independently audited collection total.
- B. As evidence of perceived wealth and extraction, qualified by literary genre and uncertain unit comparison.
- C. As the official pay bill of Indian troops at Thermopylae.
- D. As proof that Gandara and Hindush were one identical province.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Ancient talents, purity, conversion and collection cannot be reduced to a modern audited sum. [Q6-A]
- **B:** Correct: The figure signals exceptional fiscal reputation while retaining unit and rhetoric limits. [Q6-B]
- **C:** Tribute and troop catalogues are separate passages and the figure is not a payroll. [Q6-C]
- **D:** Herodotus can distinguish Gandarians and Indians; his categories do not erase the distinction. [Q6-D]

Examiner trap 6: A famous number earns marks only when its evidentiary status travels with it.

Q7

What do Xerxes-era troop references most securely indicate?

- A. Every soldier was a centrally salaried Persian citizen recruited through one standard imperial payroll without local political mediation.
- B. Indian troops alone defeated the Greeks.
- C. Eastern peoples participated in imperial military obligations, possibly through locally mediated contingents.
- D. Xerxes directly administered every village east of the Beas.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Imperial contingents could be supplied through diverse subjects and local authorities. [Q7-A]
- **B:** Herodotus's catalogue does not make Indian troops the sole or decisive force. [Q7-B]
- **C:** Correct: Participation supports military incorporation without a uniform standing-army model. [Q7-C]
- **D:** Troop service cannot map universal direct administration or a Beas frontier. [Q7-D]

Examiner trap 7: Contingent service proves obligation more readily than administrative uniformity.

Q8

Which conclusion about Achaemenid satrapy is best?

- A. Satrapy meant an identical bureaucracy imposed without local rulers everywhere with the same official hierarchy, tax schedule and garrison density in every locality.
- B. Herodotus's tribute districts and Old Persian lands always had one-to-one borders.
- C. No palace found in India proves there was no Achaemenid power at all.
- D. Provincial supervision, tribute and levies could coexist with local mediation and variable control.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** A vast diverse empire normally relied on local structures as well as appointed supervision. [Q8-A]
- **B:** Different source classifications serve different purposes and cannot be overlaid mechanically. [Q8-B]
- **C:** Architectural absence limits reconstruction but does not erase inscriptions, coins and troop evidence. [Q8-C]
- **D:** Correct: This graded model explains real incorporation without inventing uniform depth. [Q8-D]

Examiner trap 8: Avoid the false binary of total bureaucracy versus no rule.

Q9

Kharoshthi is best described as:

- A. A right-to-left north-western script structurally related to Aramaic and locally adapted.
- B. A Greek alphabet created personally by Alexander at Taxila for a uniform Greek-speaking administration extending across the entire subcontinent.
- C. A south-Indian script derived directly from Tamil-Brahmi.
- D. A Persian language rather than a writing system.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Direction and sign relationships support Aramaic derivation with adaptation to local speech. [Q9-A]
- **B:** Alexander neither created the script nor turned it into a Greek alphabet. [Q9-B]
- **C:** Its core zone is the north-west; this derivation reverses geography and chronology. [Q9-C]
- **D:** Kharoshthi is a script that wrote languages, not itself the Persian language. [Q9-D]

Examiner trap 9: Script, language, direction and region are four separate elimination checks.

Q10

Which claim avoids blanket Persianisation?

- A. All Mauryan institutions were copied unchanged from Achaemenid satrapies including revenue departments, provincial borders and court rituals without adaptation.
- B. Coins, scribal habits and forms moved selectively, while local traditions reshaped them.
- C. Indian trade began only after Darius and stopped after Xerxes.
- D. Punch-marked coinage was merely imported Persian currency.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Parallels do not demonstrate line-by-line institutional descent. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: Contact widened repertoires without erasing local agency or prior networks. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Routes and exchange predated Achaemenid expansion and survived its decline. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Achaemenid coins circulated, but Indian punch-marked traditions cannot be reduced to imports. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: Influence is not copying; contact is not cultural replacement.

Q11

Which sequence correctly orders Alexander's campaign?

- A. Taxila -> Gedrosia -> Hydaspes -> Hindu Kush with no intervening river campaign or return phase needed before the desert crossing.
- B. Hydaspes -> Hindu Kush -> Indus -> Beas
- C. Hindu Kush/highlands -> Indus/Taxila -> Hydaspes -> Beas
- D. Beas -> Aornos -> Taxila -> Patala

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Gedrosia belongs to the return after the Punjab and lower-Indus phases. [Q11-A]
- **B:** The Hindu Kush approach preceded the Indus crossing and Hydaspes. [Q11-B]

- **C:** Correct: The sequence moves from highland security to the Punjab limit. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Aornos and Taxila preceded the Beas; Patala followed it during the descent. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Chronology must be read as a route, not memorised as disconnected names.

Q12

Ambhi's response to Alexander shows:

- A. A unified national command ordering strategic retreat accepted by every frontier ruler as binding policy for a single national coalition.
- B. That Taxila had no political interests of its own.
- C. That all north-western rulers passively surrendered.
- D. A regional alliance choice shaped by local rivalry, supply and political calculation.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** No modern-national command united the frontier polities. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Taxila's ruler acted precisely because local interests and rivalries mattered. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Porus, highland communities and Malloi provide clear counter-evidence. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: Alliance was agency, not proof of collective Indian submission. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: Judge ancient actors within regional politics, not modern patriotic categories.

Q13

At Hydaspes, the first operational problem was:

- A. Crossing a watched, seasonally difficult Jhelum before deploying against Porus.
- B. Capturing the Ganga delta before the monsoon where Alexander expected Porus to deploy before any crossing of the Jhelum was required.
- C. Destroying a Persian fleet in the Arabian Sea.
- D. Defending Taxila from Seleucus I.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: River surveillance and conditions made deception and crossing central to the battle plan. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Alexander never reached the Ganga delta; the battle was in the Punjab. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Hydaspes was a land-river campaign against Porus, not a Persian naval battle. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Seleucus belongs to a later successor phase after Alexander's death. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: Start battle analysis with terrain and the tactical problem it created.

Q14

Which statement about elephants at Hydaspes is safest?

- A. They were absent from Porus's army.
- B. They created shock and formation problems, but wounded animals could also disrupt Porus's own line.
- C. They alone defeated Alexander and forced the Beas mutiny during the battle and immediately converted the later troop refusal into a battlefield defeat at Hydaspes.
- D. They prove every Indian army used one identical tactical doctrine.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Major Greek accounts give elephants a central role in Porus's deployment. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: Elephants were significant without being either invincible or useless. [Q14-B]
- **C:** The Beas refusal occurred later and cannot be collapsed into the Hydaspes outcome. [Q14-C]
- **D:** One battle does not establish a universal subcontinental doctrine. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: Close options often force a false choice between decisive and irrelevant.

Q15

Why was Porus restored after Hydaspes?

- A. Because the sources unanimously say Porus won the battle outright and the subsequent territorial settlement is therefore an uncontested surrender by Alexander.
- B. Because Alexander abolished indirect rule everywhere else.
- C. Retaining a capable local ruler reduced occupation costs and stabilised a contested region.
- D. Because Porus became king of the entire Ganga plain.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Greek narratives claim Macedonian battlefield success despite admiring Porus. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Alexander repeatedly used local rulers and changing subordinate arrangements. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: Restoration served political control after a costly battle. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Porus's enlarged authority remained north-western and did not cover the Ganga plain. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Separate a battlefield verdict from the political logic of settlement.

Q16

The Alexander-Porus medallion should be used as:

- A. A photograph of the exact duel narrated by Plutarch with its image functioning as a literal eyewitness record of a one-to-one royal duel.
- B. Proof that Porus minted all Alexander's Indian currency.
- C. An uncontested dated record naming both rulers in its inscription.
- D. Suggestive victory iconography whose production, attribution and scene require qualification.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Coin imagery constructs sovereignty and does not photograph a single encounter. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Issuer and mint cannot be transferred to Porus without evidence. [Q16-B]
- **C:** The famous type lacks the simple named caption imagined here and its context is debated. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: It supports ideology and commemoration more safely than literal event detail. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Numismatic images prove representation before narrative literalism.

Q17

Which factor belongs in the Hyphasis explanation?

- A. Accumulated fatigue interacting with rivers, monsoon, logistics, resistance and eastern-force reports.
- B. A single battle at the Beas in which a united Indian army destroyed Alexander followed by a decisive field battle in which a common Indian command expelled the army.
- C. A royal decree from Darius ordering Macedonian withdrawal.
- D. The sudden appearance of Indo-Greek kings from the second century BCE.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: The halt emerged from interacting operational and morale pressures. [Q17-A]
- **B:** No such united battle occurred; the troops refused further advance. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Darius III was dead and no Achaemenid decree controlled Alexander's army. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Indo-Greek kingdoms belong to a much later successor history. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: Cumulative causation defeats hero myths and single-factor memorisation.

Q18

How should Nanda army figures in Greek accounts be used?

- **A:** As exact censuses proving each troop type beyond dispute and can therefore be converted directly into exact daily rations and battlefield deployment.
- **B:** As evidence of a formidable eastern reputation, with rhetorical and intelligence limits.
- **C:** As Mauryan statistics from Ashoka's inscriptions.
- **D:** As proof Alexander had already fought the Nandas.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The figures vary among authors and are not audited manpower returns. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct: Reputation affected expectations even when exact totals are unreliable. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Ashoka's edicts do not provide these Nanda army tables. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Alexander stopped at the Beas and did not fight the Nanda state. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: An unreliable number can still reveal a reliable perception.

Q19

What does the Malloi episode demonstrate?

- **A:** All resistance ended immediately after Hydaspes because all local groups had accepted Macedonian authority after Porus was restored.
- **B:** Alexander never descended the Indus.
- **C:** Return through conquered space still required hard fighting and nearly produced a command catastrophe.
- **D:** The Malloi were a Persian satrapy loyal to Xerxes.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Malloi resistance is counter-evidence to smooth pacification. [Q19-A]
- **B:** The river descent is a major phase after the Beas halt. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: Alexander's serious wound exposes continuing military risk. [Q19-C]
- **D:** The episode belongs to the Macedonian return, not Xerxes's empire. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: Do not let the famous Hydaspes battle erase later resistance.

Q20

Patala is most relevant as:

- **A:** The securely identified capital of Porus beyond the Beas whose fixed coastline and political boundaries can be transferred directly onto a modern map.
- **B:** The place where Darius wrote the Behistun inscription.
- **C:** The origin city of Kharoshthi in a surviving foundation charter.
- **D:** A lower-Indus delta node for arrangements, reconnaissance and fleet preparation, with geographical caution.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Porus's power is normally placed between Jhelum and Chenab, not at the delta. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Behistun is in western Iran, not the Indus delta. [Q20-B]
- **C:** No Patala charter records the invention of Kharoshthi. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: Delta strategy matters while ancient channels and exact location remain debated. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: Ancient delta geography cannot be plotted with modern coastline certainty.

Q21

Nearchus is important because:

- **A.** His lost participant account, preserved especially through Arrian, records the coastal voyage westward.
- **B.** He wrote the Behistun inscription for Darius and left a complete autograph route text from the coastal voyage.
- **C.** He was Porus's elephant commander at Hydaspes.
- **D.** His surviving autograph gives exact casualty totals for Gedrosia.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Participant proximity combines with later textual transmission. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Behistun predates Nearchus, and no complete Nearchus autograph survives. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Nearchus was a Macedonian naval commander, not Porus's officer. [Q21-C]
- **D:** The original work does not survive and exact loss totals remain disputed. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: Always name both the early witness and the later transmitter.

Q22

Why must Onesicritus be read cautiously?

- **A.** He was an Achaemenid king with no connection to Alexander.
- **B.** His participant status is offset by later transmission and ancient criticism of marvellous ethnography.
- **C.** His text survives as a complete neutral ship log independently preserved from the voyage without later editing, quotation or hostile criticism.
- **D.** He alone provides an Indian-language narrative of the campaign.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Onesicritus accompanied Alexander and wrote about the expedition. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: Proximity does not erase literary self-fashioning or fabulous material. [Q22-B]
- **C:** The original work is lost and what survives is mediated. [Q22-C]
- **D:** He wrote in Greek within the Alexander tradition, not as an Indian chronicler. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Eyewitness is not a synonym for complete, unbiased or independently surviving.

Q23

Arrian's value and limit are best paired as:

- **A.** No route detail; contemporary Indian royal archive
- **B.** Eyewitness diary; no literary agenda composed during the campaign and checked line by line against an Indian royal archive.
- **C.** Detailed synthesis using participant sources; second-century CE selection and heroic-military framing

- D. Achaemenid tax tablet; exact satrapy map

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Arrian supplies abundant route detail but not an Indian royal archive. [Q23-A]
- **B:** He lived centuries later and wrote a crafted history. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: Earlier-source access and temporal or genre distance must be held together. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Arrian is neither an Achaemenid tablet nor a cadastral cartographer. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: A late source may preserve early information without becoming contemporary.

Q24

Plutarch's famous Porus dialogue is safest as:

- A. A stenographic transcript verified by an Indian inscription recorded simultaneously by court stenographers and confirmed in a surviving bilingual treaty.
- B. Proof Porus was elected ruler of Macedonia.
- C. An exact treaty clause fixing every territorial boundary.
- D. A biographical scene expressing exemplary kingship, not guaranteed verbatim speech.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** No bilingual transcript or matching Indian inscription establishes verbatim wording. [Q24-A]
- **B:** The dialogue concerns royal conduct after battle, not Macedonian succession. [Q24-B]
- **C:** It cannot function as a surveyed settlement document. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct: Biography preserves memory while shaping character and moral example. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: Memorable ancient speech is usually the highest-risk evidence class.

Q25

Alexander's arrangements relied chiefly on:

- A. A mix of retained rulers, changing satraps, garrisons and settlements along corridors.
- B. A uniform Mauryan-style bureaucracy across the whole subcontinent organised through permanent departments identical to those later described for the Mauryas.
- C. Only direct Macedonian village administration with no local intermediaries.
- D. Permanent Indo-Greek dynasties already ruling Gandhara art centres.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Layered indirect and military controls economised force. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Mauryan institutions belong to later consolidation and cannot be projected backward. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Porus, Ambhi and Abhisara contradict the no-intermediary claim. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Later Indo-Greek states did not exist as Alexander's permanent system. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: List the control instruments, then test how long each survived.

Q26

Why did Macedonian control fragment rapidly?

- A. Kharoshthi prevented officers from communicating because script direction made all orders unintelligible to every Macedonian and local officer.

- B. Personal command, shifting appointments, succession wars and local reassertion outran consolidation.
- C. Darius I reconquered the Indus after 323 BCE.
- D. The whole army settled permanently at Taxila and abandoned politics.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Script choice does not explain imperial succession and military fragmentation. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: Alexander's death exposed a corridor system dependent on personal supremacy. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Darius I had died more than a century before Alexander. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Forces and officers followed diverse routes; no universal Taxila settlement occurred. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Rapid collapse is evidence about institutional depth, not proof nothing happened.

Q27

Which formulation best links Alexander to the Mauryas?

- A. Alexander created the Mauryan Empire before leaving India through an administrative structure created by Alexander before his departure from the Indus.
- B. Chandragupta certainly trained as a Macedonian officer.
- C. Fragmentation was one favourable condition later exploited by an independently rooted Magadhan-Mauryan power.
- D. Seleucus was Alexander's governor of Pataliputra in 326 BCE.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Mauryan formation followed separate Magadhan and Chandragupta processes. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Late traditions do not establish this specific military career. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: The wording recognises opportunity without deterministic causation. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Seleucus's later eastern role belongs to successor conflict. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: Use one condition rather than the cause when linking the invasion to Mauryan expansion.

Q28

Which consequence is overclaimed?

- A. Greek accounts enlarged external geographical knowledge of the north-west when route claims are checked against topographical and genre limits.
- B. Campaign routes and settlements intensified existing transregional contacts.
- C. The 326-325 BCE sequence provides a useful chronological anchor.
- D. Alexander personally created mature Gandhara art and all later Indo-Greek coinage.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Route narratives are a genuine informational consequence, though source-critical. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Intensified is safer than invented because earlier contacts already existed. [Q28-B]
- **C:** The campaign gives an important external date for connected events. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: Those mature forms belong to later patrons, states and workshops. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: Do not collapse a long Hellenistic afterlife into one conqueror's agency.

Q29

Which answer framework is strongest?

- A. Define both episodes, map the frontier, rank evidence, trace each sequence, compare mechanisms and qualify.
- B. List Alexander legends, quote army totals and end with national unity while leaving the geographical sequence, source classes and causal hierarchy unspecified.
- C. Treat Darius, Seleucus and Indo-Greeks as one continuous invasion.
- D. Discuss only art and omit territory, chronology and sources.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This sequence answers scale, evidence, causation and comparison together. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Legends and totals without criticism convert rhetoric into evidence. [Q29-B]
- **C:** The episodes are chronologically and institutionally distinct. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Art is one bounded legacy and cannot replace the campaign spine. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: A framework is a safeguard against map, chronology and source errors.

Q30

Which statement best distinguishes later Indo-Greeks?

- A. They were Alexander's unchanged garrisons lasting for two centuries without any dynastic break, successor conflict or new migration into the north-west.
- B. They were later Hellenistic polities and cultural formations, not Alexander's campaign itself.
- C. They ruled India before the Achaemenids.
- D. Their portrait coins prove Alexander invented Kharoshthi.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Succession and new dynasties separate later kingdoms from Alexander's appointments. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: The distinction prevents chronological collapse while allowing a contact afterlife. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Achaemenid expansion and Alexander predate the principal Indo-Greek kingdoms. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Coin portraiture and Kharoshthi cannot be joined by this unsupported claim. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Later Hellenistic does not mean immediate Macedonian continuity.

Q31

What does no blanket Persianisation mean?

- A. Achaemenid contact had no effects whatsoever despite the inscriptional, numismatic and scribal evidence for selective eastern connections.
- B. Every Iranian parallel is fictional.
- C. Specific scripts, coins, vocabulary or forms could travel without uniform cultural replacement.
- D. Only Greek contact influenced the north-west.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Kharoshthi-Aramaic and monetary evidence make total denial untenable. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Critical comparison distinguishes stronger and weaker parallels rather than rejecting all. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: Selective adaptation lies between isolation and total copying. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Achaemenid evidence predates and differs from Macedonian-Hellenistic contact. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: Rejecting totalisation must not become denial of specific evidence.

Q32

Which qualified verdict is most defensible?

- A. Foreign invasions directly unified India under Alexander.
- B. The episodes were irrelevant because territorial reach was limited so their limited territorial reach eliminates every political, cultural and informational effect.
- C. Achaemenid and Macedonian rule were identical and permanent.
- D. They were bounded interventions with variable control and selective longer effects on scripts, routes and knowledge.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Later consolidation had its own Magadhan-Mauryan causes. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Limited rule can still alter networks, knowledge and opportunity structures. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Duration, evidence and administrative mechanisms differ, and Macedonian coherence fragmented. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: The verdict balances scale, agency, consequence and evidentiary caution. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: Reject both conquest romance and dismissive minimalism.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ ROUTING AND KEY DISCIPLINE

- Repository routing audits for 2018-2023, 2024-2025 and 2026 locate **no direct UPSC Prelims or GS-I Mains PYQ owned by Iranian and Macedonian Invasions**. No direct question or answer key is fabricated.
- The verified 2019 GS-I demand on Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art is routed to the Central Asian Contacts/Kushanas and art owners. It is not relabelled as an Alexander PYQ here.
- The questions below are explicitly original. UPSC publishes no official descriptive model answers; these are examiner-oriented instructional models.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE - EXACTLY SIX SOLVED QUESTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS - 150 WORDS

Question: Explain why Achaemenid rule in north-western India should be described as real but uneven.

Model answer:

Achaemenid power in the north-west was real because contemporary royal evidence places Gandara and Hindush within Darius's imperial world. Behistun names Gandara, while DNa at Naqsh-e Rostam includes Gandara and Hindush; Herodotus adds tribute and troop obligations. These claims show more than casual contact: routes, levies, fiscal demands and satrapal supervision connected the region to the empire. Yet depth was uneven. Royal lists do not survey borders, Herodotus's twentieth district is not identical to every inscriptional land, and local rulers probably mediated obligations. Chaman-i Hazouri and Bhir coin contexts indicate circulation, while local bent-bar forms suggest adaptation and autonomy rather than one royal currency. Sparse architecture limits reconstruction but cannot erase textual and numismatic evidence. Thus Achaemenid rule combined imperial inclusion with variable local control, not either uniform bureaucracy or merely nominal contact.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence, explains what the evidence proves, and carries chronology, source or causation qualifications into the verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS - 150 WORDS

Question: Why did Alexander's army stop at the Hyphasis? Give a multi-causal explanation.

Model answer:

The Hyphasis refusal was a cumulative operational and morale crisis, not a battle defeat or sudden fear of one Indian king. The army had campaigned for years from the Balkans through the Achaemenid world and Central Asia, producing fatigue, homesickness and replacement shortages. Punjab's monsoon, swollen rivers, humidity, sickness and lengthening supply lines made further advance costlier. Highland warfare and the difficult Hydaspes battle against Porus had corrected expectations about resistance and war elephants. Greek authors add reports of powerful Gangetic and Nanda forces; their troop totals are rhetorical, but the reputation itself could influence morale. Alexander's appeals and Coenus's speech are later literary constructions, so no single motive should be treated as a transcript. Fatigue reduced willingness, logistics enlarged risk, resistance supplied experience and eastern reports darkened the horizon. Their interaction, rather than Indian political unity, forced command to accept the Beas as the limit.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence, explains what the evidence proves, and carries chronology, source or causation qualifications into the verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS - 250 WORDS

Question: Assess the importance and limits of Achaemenid influence on ancient India.

Model answer:

Achaemenid influence was important chiefly as a north-western imperial and contact context; it was neither pan-Indian nor a wholesale model for later states. Politically, Behistun names Gandara and DNā names Gandara and Hindush among Darius's subject lands. Herodotus's tribute districts and Xerxes-era contingents indicate fiscal and military obligation. These sources place parts of the north-west within a wider empire, although lists do not reveal fixed borders or uniform administration.

The clearest durable cultural link is scribal. Imperial Aramaic circulated across the empire, and Kharoshthi later developed in the north-west as a right-to-left script structurally related to Aramaic. Its adaptation to Indo-Aryan phonology shows local transformation, while the absence of a foundation record prevents naming one inventor or date. Monetary contexts at Chaman-i Hazouri and Bhir show Achaemenid coin circulation alongside local forms; they demonstrate exchange, not a Persian origin for all punch-marked coinage. Later comparisons involving *dipi/lipi*, bell-shaped capitals and court forms may indicate selective transmission, but chronological distance and indigenous components rule out line-by-line Mauryan copying.

Economically, imperial routes could intensify movement of soldiers, merchants, scribes and artisans, though such networks predated Darius. The verdict is selective adaptation under uneven frontier rule: strongest for Aramaic-Kharoshthi and imperial inclusion, cautious for administration, coin origins and Mauryan art.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence, explains what the evidence proves, and carries chronology, source or causation qualifications into the verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS - 250 WORDS

Question: Reconstruct the Battle of Hydaspes with attention to geography, tactics and source criticism.

Model answer:

Hydaspes in 326 BCE was first a river-crossing problem. Porus watched the Jhelum during difficult seasonal water and expected Alexander to cross from the visible main camp. In the surviving Greek tradition, Alexander used repeated feints, left Craterus opposite Porus and moved a selected force upstream under storm or darkness. After crossing, Macedonian cavalry engaged Porus's advance force and pressured the flanks, while infantry confronted a line organised around elephants. Coenus's manoeuvre and cavalry superiority are presented as decisive; elephants caused shock and disorder but, when wounded, could also disrupt Porus's formations. Wet ground is said to have reduced chariot effectiveness.

This reconstruction is plausible because classical accounts agree on the broad problems of crossing, manoeuvre and elephants. It is nevertheless source-dependent. Arrian wrote in the second century CE, using Ptolemy and Aristobulus; Curtius and Diodorus preserve variants. Their speeches, force sizes, casualties and perfectly coordinated sequences serve heroic narratives. The Alexander-Porus medallion may commemorate victory ideology, but its production and scene are debated. No equivalent Indian battle narrative survives.

The safest conclusion is a costly Macedonian battlefield success followed by political accommodation. Porus's restoration does not prove he won; it shows Alexander's need for indirect rule. Geography shaped tactical choices, but later Greek storytelling controls their precision.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence, explains what the evidence proves, and carries chronology, source or causation qualifications into the verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS - 250 WORDS

Question: Compare the Iranian and Macedonian interventions in north-western India in terms of nature, evidence and consequences.

Model answer:

The interventions shared a connected north-western frontier but differed in duration, mechanism and evidence. Achaemenid incorporation developed from the sixth century BCE and is firmest under Darius I. Behistun names Gandara; DNa includes Gandara and Hindush; Xerxes's lists and Herodotus's contingents suggest continuing obligation. Its mechanisms were satrapal supervision, tribute, levies, routes and local mediation. Contemporary inscriptions are authoritative for claimed inclusion but too formulaic to map uniform control.

Alexander's intervention was a rapid 327-325 BCE campaign after the fall of Darius III. It moved through the Hindu Kush, crossed the Indus with Ambhi's support, fought Porus at Hydaspes, stopped at the Hyphasis and descended the Indus amid Malloi resistance. Control rested on restored rulers, changing satraps, garrisons and settlements; it fragmented after 323 BCE. Its narratives are detailed but late: Arrian, Curtius, Diodorus, Plutarch and Justin transmit lost traditions through distinct genres.

Legacies differ. Imperial Aramaic supplies the strongest context for Kharoshthi, and coin circulation reflects an imperial monetary frontier; wholesale Persian influence on Mauryan institutions remains excessive. Alexander intensified route knowledge and created a political opening later exploitable by Chandragupta, but did not cause the Mauryan Empire. Mature Indo-Greek coinage and Gandhara art belong to later histories. Thus Achaemenid impact was longer and administrative-scribal, Macedonian impact shorter and military-geographical; both produced selective contact without conquering India.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence, explains what the evidence proves, and carries chronology, source or causation qualifications into the verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS - 250 WORDS

Question: 'The history of these invasions is also a history of sources.' Critically examine.

Model answer:

The apparent scale and meaning of both interventions change with the evidence used. Achaemenid royal inscriptions are contemporary: Behistun names Gandara, while DNa and Xerxes-era lists include Gandara and Hindush. They establish imperial claims, yet their purpose is to display ordered kingship, not surveyed borders. Persepolis reliefs represent subject peoples without measuring administrative depth. Herodotus adds the twentieth tribute district, 360 talents of gold dust and eastern contingents, but Greek genre, converted units and ethnographic rhetoric prevent modern fiscal precision.

Alexander's campaign has the opposite problem: abundant detail but late survival. Ptolemy, Aristobulus, Nearchus and Onesicritus wrote as participants or near contemporaries, but their works are lost or fragmentary. Arrian selected Ptolemy and Aristobulus in the second century CE; Curtius dramatised kingship, Plutarch wrote moral biography, Diodorus universal history and Justin an epitome. Agreements may reflect shared sources, while speeches, motives, casualties, totals and marvels are especially risky. Archaeology and coins can test circulation, settlement and iconography, but rarely narrate a battle or draw a border.

Source criticism should grade, not paralyse, reconstruction. Achaemenid inclusion, Alexander's broad route, Hydaspes, the Beas halt and rapid fragmentation remain defensible. Exact satrapies, numbers, speeches and cultural causation remain qualified. The best history distinguishes attested claim, probable control, campaign passage, settlement and later legacy.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence, explains what the evidence proves, and carries chronology, source or causation qualifications into the verdict.